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The Dark Mysteries of Herculaneum

Italy's Buried City and the Dark Secrets Preserved by Vesuvius

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Introduction

Herculaneum was an ancient Roman city on the coast of Campania, in the shadow of Mount Vesuvius, approximately eight kilometers southeast of Naples. Founded between the sixth and seventh centuries BC by the Oscans, an ancient Italic people, the city passed through Etruscan, Greek, Samnite, and Roman control before becoming a Roman municipium in 89 BC. Its name derives from the Greek hero Heracles -- Hercules in Roman mythology -- and according to legend, the city was founded by Hercules himself as he passed through the Italian peninsula during his tenth labor, the capture of the cattle of Geryon. Whether the legend is true or not, the connection to Hercules gave the city its name and its mythological significance.

By the first century AD, Herculaneum had become a seaside resort for wealthy Roman citizens -- a quiet, elegant town of villas, baths, and gardens, with a small harbor, a population of perhaps four or five thousand, and a view of the Bay of Naples that was, and remains, one of the most beautiful in the Mediterranean. The city was smaller than its neighbor Pompeii -- approximately fifty acres compared to Pompeii's one hundred and ten -- but it was wealthier, more intimate, and more beautiful. Its streets were lined with fine houses, its public buildings were well-maintained, and its residents enjoyed a standard of living that was among the highest in the Roman world.

All of this ended on a single day in the autumn of 79 AD, when Mount Vesuvius erupted. The eruption, one of the most catastrophic volcanic events in European history, destroyed Herculaneum in approximately two hours. Unlike Pompeii, which was buried under a layer of ash that preserved the city in a relatively gentle embrace, Herculaneum was buried under a pyroclastic flow -- a superheated avalanche of gas, ash, and volcanic debris that swept down the side of the volcano at hundreds of kilometers per hour and engulfed the city at a temperature of approximately four hundred degrees Celsius. The pyroclastic flow carbonized the city's organic materials -- wood, food, furniture, documents -- and buried Herculaneum under twenty meters of volcanic deposits that hardened into a substance resembling rock.

Herculaneum was lost for nearly seventeen centuries. The city was rediscovered in 1709, and systematic excavations began in 1738, but the difficulty of excavating through the hardened volcanic material meant that only a fraction of the city has been uncovered. Among the most chilling discoveries were the skeletons -- more than three hundred of them -- found in the boat houses along the ancient shoreline, where the residents of Herculaneum had fled to escape the eruption and where they died, instantly, when the pyroclastic surge reached the coast. The skeletons, preserved in the positions in which they fell, are a direct and tangible record of the human cost of the eruption -- not casts or imprints, as at Pompeii, but actual human remains.

Herculaneum is the Italian entry of the Dark Mysteries series, which examines haunted and historically significant locations around the world. Herculaneum is not a haunted house or a ghost story in the traditional sense. It is a ghost city -- a place where an entire civilization was extinguished in a single day and where the remains of that civilization, including the remains of its people, have been preserved for nearly two thousand years. The "haunting" of Herculaneum is not a matter of apparitions or unexplained sounds. It is the haunting of a place where the dead are visible, where the moment of death is preserved, and where the visitor stands in a city that was alive one morning and dead by afternoon.

The story of Herculaneum is a story of opposites -- creation and destruction, preservation and loss, life and death -- held together by the volcano that both built and destroyed the city. Mount Vesuvius created the promontory on which Herculaneum was built, enriched the soil that fed its population, and provided the stone that built its houses. The same volcano, in a single afternoon, erased the city from the face of the earth. The paradox of Vesuvius -- the source of life and the agent of death -- is the defining paradox of Herculaneum, and it gives the story a depth that goes beyond the simple narrative of a natural disaster.

The Dark Mysteries series has examined haunted locations across the world, from the Tower of London to the Amityville Horror, from the Paris Catacombs to the Island of the Dolls. Herculaneum is different from all of them. It is not a single haunted house or a specific ghost story. It is an entire city -- a civilization -- preserved at the moment of its annihilation. The "ghosts" of Herculaneum are not spirits that walk the ruins at night. They are the skeletons of three hundred people, lying in the boat houses where they died, visible to anyone who enters the site. The haunting is not supernatural. It is archaeological. And it is, in its way, more powerful than any ghost story, because the dead are not a legend or a rumor -- they are present, tangible, and undeniable.

The preservation of Herculaneum is a gift and a burden. It is a gift because it provides a window into the ancient world that is clearer and more complete than any other. The carbonized wood, the preserved food, the surviving

scrolls -- these are treasures that give us knowledge of Roman life that would otherwise be lost. It is a burden because the preservation of the dead -- the three hundred skeletons in the boat houses -- places a responsibility on the living. The dead cannot be ignored. They are there, visible, and they demand a response. The response -- whether it is reverence, grief, curiosity, or something else -- is what the visitor brings to Herculaneum, and it is what makes the site more than an archaeological attraction. It is a place where the living meet the dead, and where the meeting cannot be avoided.

Chapter 1: What Happened Here?

Herculaneum was located on a promontory by the sea, on the coast of Campania in southwestern Italy. The promontory was formed by earlier eruptions of Mount Vesuvius, and the city's location -- on a cliff overlooking the Bay of Naples, with the volcano behind it and the sea before it -- gave it a position of natural beauty and natural defense. The city was connected to the Serino aqueduct, which provided fresh water, and it had a small harbor that served its fishing industry and its trade with neighboring cities. The fertile volcanic soil of the surrounding area supported agriculture, and the tuff stone from earlier volcanic deposits provided building material.

The city was laid out in a grid pattern -- a Roman system of urban planning that divided the city into blocks intersected by three north-south streets (decumani) and five east-west streets (cardi). The streets were paved with stone and lined with houses, shops, and public buildings. The city had a forum, a basilica, public baths, a theater, a palaestra (gymnasium), shops, and necropolises -- all the facilities of a wealthy Roman town. Many of these structures are still buried under the volcanic deposits and have not been excavated, but those that have been uncovered reveal a city of remarkable sophistication and beauty.

The houses of Herculaneum were among its most impressive features. The city's wealthiest residents -- Roman elites who used Herculaneum as a seaside retreat -- built villas with frescoed walls, mosaic floors, central pools, terraced gardens, and panoramic sea views. The Villa of the Papyri, the most famous of these villas, was a vast estate that included a library of carbonized papyrus scrolls -- the only surviving ancient library in the world. The villa belonged to Lucius Calpurnius Piso Caesoninus, a Roman senator and the father-in-law of Julius Caesar, and it was a symbol of the wealth and culture that defined Herculaneum before its destruction.

The eruption of Mount Vesuvius in 79 AD was one of the most devastating volcanic events in human history. The eruption began in the morning, with a column of ash and pumice that rose approximately thirty kilometers into the atmosphere. The column, shaped like an umbrella pine tree -- a description preserved in the letter of Pliny the Younger, who witnessed the eruption from across the bay -- rained ash and pumice on the surrounding area, including Pompeii, which was buried under several meters of falling material over the course of the day.

Herculaneum, however, was not affected by the initial ash fall. The prevailing winds carried the ash toward Pompeii, and Herculaneum experienced a relatively quiet morning. But the eruption was not over. In the early afternoon, the column of ash collapsed under its own weight, and the first pyroclastic flow -- a ground-hugging avalanche of superheated gas, ash, and volcanic debris -- surged down the side of the volcano toward Herculaneum. The flow, traveling at hundreds of kilometers per hour and at a temperature of approximately four hundred degrees Celsius, reached the city in minutes. The destruction of Herculaneum was, according to geological estimates, completed in approximately two hours.

The pyroclastic flow that destroyed Herculaneum was fundamentally different from the ash fall that buried Pompeii. The ash at Pompeii accumulated gradually, allowing some residents to escape and preserving the city in a relatively intact state. The pyroclastic flow at Herculaneum was instantaneous and lethal. Anyone caught in the flow was killed immediately -- the temperature and the force of the surge left no chance of survival. The flow also carbonized the city's organic materials, turning wood into charcoal and preserving objects that would otherwise have decayed -- furniture, food, wooden structures, and even papyrus documents.

The eruption's dual role also deserves to be stated as the book's central paradox, because it governs everything that follows. The same event that killed Herculaneum is the only reason it can be known. Every other seaside resort of Roman Campania -- the villas of Baiae, the coast of Misenum, a dozen towns of comparable wealth -- was lived in, dismantled, quarried, and forgotten; their frescoes became lime, their furniture firewood, their names footnotes. Herculaneum survives, in houses and doorframes and bread, because it was sealed at the moment of its death. The uncomfortable arithmetic is that the worst day in the city's history was also the only one that made it immortal, and this skews everything archaeology can say about the Roman world: the cities we know best are the cities that suffered catastrophes, because catastrophe was the only preservative the ancient Mediterranean reliably supplied. The record of Roman daily life is therefore, in part, a casualty list. Herculaneum's bread is in the

oven because everyone died; its furniture is intact because no one lived to wear it out. When this book examines the city in the following chapters, it is always examining a place described to us by the thing that destroyed it -- the one witness whose testimony cannot be cross-examined.

After the eruption, Herculaneum was buried under approximately twenty meters of volcanic deposits -- a mixture of ash, pumice, and pyroclastic material that hardened over time into a substance resembling rock. The city was lost. The location was forgotten, and over the centuries, a new town -- Resina, now known as Ercolano -- was built on top of the buried ruins. The city that had been Hercules' city, that had been a Roman seaside resort, that had been buried by a volcano, disappeared from the landscape and from memory.

The rediscovery of Herculaneum began in 1709, when a farmer digging a well struck the wall of the ancient theater. Systematic excavations began in 1738, under the patronage of the King of Naples, and have continued, with interruptions, to the present day. The difficulty of excavating through the hardened volcanic material -- which is far more compact and difficult to remove than the loose ash at Pompeii -- means that only a fraction of the city has been uncovered. Approximately one-quarter of the ancient city is visible today, and much of the site remains buried under the modern town of Ercolano.

The contrast between the beauty of Herculaneum's setting and the violence of its destruction is one of the defining characteristics of the story. The city was located on one of the most beautiful coastlines in the Mediterranean -- a stretch of shore that, to this day, draws visitors from around the world. The Bay of Naples, with its blue water, its islands, and its backdrop of mountains, was a setting of extraordinary natural beauty. The Romans who built villas in Herculaneum chose the location for its views, its climate, and its tranquility. The same beauty that attracted the Roman elite to Herculaneum makes the destruction of the city all the more poignant -- a place of extraordinary loveliness that was transformed, in two hours, into a tomb.

The relationship between Herculaneum and the sea is central to the story. The city was built on the coast, its economy was connected to the sea, and its residents fled to the sea when the eruption began. The ancient shoreline, where the skeletons were found, is now approximately five hundred meters inland -- the volcanic deposits that buried the city extended the coastline, and the modern town of Ercolano is built on land that was, in 79 AD, under water. The change in the coastline is itself a measure of the eruption's power -- the volcano did not only destroy a city, it reshaped the geography of the entire region. The ancient shoreline, now excavated and visible, is a physical record of the world that existed before the eruption and the world that was created by it.